very senior activists started acting like gatekeepers, promising organizations and individuals that they would be permitted to join the Yatra or meet Rahul Gandhi only if their demands were met. It was already difficult for us to balance diverse interests and demands. This was magnified a hundred times because of these efforts to monopolize access to the BJY. We had to make concerted efforts to reach out to each stakeholder individually to ensure they felt welcome in the BJY, and to assure them that it was their Yatra (and they did not have to kowtow to any individual or subsume their individual identities in any organization to join the BJY). This whole process was an extremely illuminating experience. Apart from an intimate understanding of local dynamics, we also learnt to remain neutral. We were patiently guided (and often pacified when things became too frustrating) by Balasaheb Thorat and Nana Patole (president of the Maharashtra Congress). Although they were always understanding towards us, we often felt embarrassed for constantly troubling them, given they already had a lot on their plates.

But all's well that ends well! Thanks to our collective efforts, we had a wide range of stakeholders working on social, economic, political and cultural issues who joined the BJY. Over 200 organizations and movements, and over 60,000 eminent citizens and patriots from Maharashtra joined Bharat Jodo (these are only the ones who formally connected with us; many more joined without registering). We tried very hard to ensure that most of them could interact with Rahul Gandhi (either in closed-door interactions during lunchtime or in walking interactions). I was fortunate to attend a few of them, and was astonished to see how frank and intense they were. I recall one such interaction with Medha Patkar, Irfan Engineer and other eminent activists. On the one hand, Medha tai was earnestly trying to flag as many people's issues as she could in the one hour that was allocated for the interaction; and on the other hand, Jairam Ramesh sir was trying hard to stick to the schedule and also ensure that Rahul Gandhi got to rest for a bit after the interactions. Both were legitimate imperatives, but eventually clashed. The interaction descended into a heated exchange and the thirty-odd activists who had come were also becoming restive, since they all wanted to put forth their issues. Things only proceeded calmly when Rahul